

Rep. Tom Emmer on The Hill Sunday with Chris Stirewalt

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HOST:

Republicans. Tom Emmer is the House Majority Whip, and he's the former chairman of the National Republican Campaign Committee. And he joined us when we were down in Dallas at the RNC to talk about all that and more. Take a listen. Are you ready to make a fearless forecast that you will succeed?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Well, I believe we are going to. I think the key is this last 54 days. Hopefully voting is going to start in several different places within the next ten days or so. The case is being made, and this is enhancing it, and I think it's going to give us a good boost as we come out of it. The case is being made by our members about what we have accomplished in the last two years. I mean, after the previous administration took us to inflation we hadn't seen in 40 years, the price of eggs, the price of gas, et cetera. Literally you see a lot of this already reset. I mean, obviously the price of gas is going to be an issue, but I think you're going to find the majority of Americans agree with the president that the evil Iranian regime, the IRGC, should never have a nuclear weapon. So I do believe not only can we hold the House, but we're going to.

HOST:

Now I've talked to your colleagues, and you're getting a lot of credit, because this is a difficult cycle, right? Every midterm for the party in power is hard. This is hard for the reason you allude to with gas prices and other things. This is a tough cycle. You're getting a ton of credit. When I talk off-camera with your colleagues, you're getting a ton of credit. But if the Republicans do not retain the House, is it time for people to think about a leadership change in the Speaker's chair or in the party leadership? Should the bar be that high? Or your chance is good enough that if you miss, Mike Johnson and his team should get a look at it?

REP. TOM EMMER:

It's interesting. Everybody wants to create like a daytime drama in the House. Not my thing. I believe we are going to hold the majority. I believe that it's going to come down to, at the end of the day, probably 10 to 15 seats. It's that close. It will be a small majority no matter what, right? I mean, literally. One of the prognosticators who has said in recent days, there are probably 209 safe Republican seats, probably 205 safe Democrat seats. There's 21 that are in play. I think it's much more narrow. So based on that, look, I believe Mike Johnson is going to remain the Speaker. I believe Steve Scalise is going to remain the leader. And I love my job as the whip. And I'm going to ask our members to continue the privilege of being their whip.

HOST:

OK. So the map, the size of the map is really the question, right? And some people say 21. Some people say 12 or 15. There is at that next bandwidth, though, and when I look at results in places like Marie Gluzenkamp Perez's district, I look at places like that and I see what the swing was like in the primary results from four years ago. There is that scenario, right, where there's 40, 35 seats in play, where it's a much bigger map. Are you you

say that's not in the cards?

REP. TOM EMMER:

I think you're going to see surprises in places like you just mentioned. Why? Because I think blue states that have been terribly managed. I think the the mood's just a little bit different as opposed to a red state where it's more of an incumbency thing and you're going to have to fight through that that downward pressure that you get. Let me put it in context for me. Everybody always wants to talk about the contract with America in 1994. Well, we're never going to have that again. The House does not drive the national message. We have 435 pieces of geography. Each one has its own unique demographic. We can be impacted by the national message. But if you have the right incumbent or candidate, you have the right message and you have enough money to do what you need to do, you can fight your way through that thing. And Washington, I think you're going to see a surprise in Washington three. I think John Brown's going to win that Minnesota. I think you could see a surprise in Michigan, Illinois.

HOST:

OK, so well, let's think so just to you, we can use Washington three because there's a lot of districts like that in the country that are predominantly suburban and then move out into the exurbs and a little bit of rural but are driven by suburban action. The problem that Republicans seem to be having is with what you'd call traditional conservatives. Right. And if you were to take Texas, we're in Texas. So if you take Texas and on the Senate race, which lucky for you, you don't have to do that one. But the problem seems to be that some of these traditional Republican suburban conservatives are not coming in. How does the president's promise of a five thousand dollar payout to every American? How do you think that's going to land with the old school fiscal conservative folks out in the suburbs?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Well, I think they're two different issues. And I understand that you have to figure out how you can categorize some different voters. Right. And you're calling them traditional conservatives. The real issue is Republicans are still a party that has disagreements internal. Sure. My grandfather was a proud Democrat. It's like they're finally having disagreements internally. But it's with the Marxists and the communists versus the socialists, not versus the big government liberals that we've become accustomed to on our side. The fight is something a little bit different. You see differences of opinion in Texas and other places. You got to get over yourself. The message is all Republicans need to turn out to vote. We need Ken Paxton to not only win, which he's going to, but to drive a big turnout because that will impact our seats. And carry you down in places like 15 in the Rio Grande Valley and do that. Carry us up. Carry.

HOST:

So but on the five grand, is that do you think is does that net out? Does the president's promise there net out a gain for you in mobilizing? Call them MAGA voters, call them whatever, call them the lower propensity quadrennial cycle voters. Does it do you get enough out of mobilizing those voters from what you might lose from somebody who says we have a 40 trillion dollar debt and this isn't the time to do one point three trillion dollar stimulus?

REP. TOM EMMER:

First, there's a Harris X survey from July 12th that said those MAGA voters that you're referring to that we've been told for two years aren't going to show up because Donald Trump's not on the ballot. Ninety percent of them said they were going to show up in that particular survey in July. The thing you're talking about, it's just

another shiny object that people want to grab on to and point to. You got to think about the fact that Donald Trump, Donald Trump's been talking about all Americans share in the success of America. He was talking about the dividend concept months before. Many dividends have been suggested. It was interesting the way he came up with it last night. And basically what he was saying, again, is all Americans should share in the success of Americans. He put a number on it. I'm sure this is the beginning of the discussion of what that might look like, but he can't do it with Democrats because they refuse to support anything that Donald Trump proposes. All right. I know you know the numbers. I know you know that.

HOST:

So the final question is everybody has a median race. There's a number there's there's a house race in your mind that you're going to be watching and say. And so if you're a Democrat, for example, you're watching Pennsylvania and there's a couple races in Pennsylvania that your Democratic counterpart says, if we can flip that one, then we can do it. What's the race that you're watching that's going to tell you that the Republicans are having the kind of night that you want? What's what's a good high watermark bellwether for you?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Well, when when you start, it'll start with Florida. Right. Right. How are we doing with those four seats that have been redistricted? Right. Where are we at? Then it's probably going to go up to North Carolina. How are we doing in North Carolina one with Laurie Buckout and Don Davis? Pennsylvania will probably take longer to come in. It will be interesting to see. I think we're going to do well in Pennsylvania, but it's that one will take longer. So then I'll probably go to the east and look at Ohio, for instance. What is Ohio looking like? Ohio nine in Toledo, the seat in Cincinnati, taking us back to the beginning of this century that we're paying attention to Ohio again. It's very exciting. Yeah. But but to your question, you also got to realize which ones are going to come in. Yeah. The earliest. So you're probably looking at New York is going to take a while, right? Yeah. But you're going to look at Ohio. You're going to look at Iowa. Iowa will come in early, right? Not early, but timely. Yes. Time in a timely fashion. Unlike California, where they just keep counting. It'll be a week or two.

HOST:

Well, I know that you'll have NewsNation on because Decision Desk HQ makes the fastest calls. Mr. Chairman, we appreciate your time. Good luck out there.

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